



FOOD FOR THOUGHT

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Boost your sports performance this summer by eating right

With temperatures soaring above 50°C, hot summers like this endanger athletes' performance and health, underlining the **critical need for hydration** and electrolyte balance.

India is experiencing its hottest summer in recorded history, with temperatures soaring to unprecedented heights. This year, Delhi's Mungeshpur recorded a staggering 52.9°C, making it the hottest place in the country. Other places like Phalodi in Rajasthan and Sirsa in Haryana have also experienced extreme temperatures, with highs of 51°C and 50.3°C, respectively.

It's important to note that the northern part of the country, which is particularly affected by this scorching heat, has 40 per cent of India's athletes who are bearing the brunt of the rising temperatures.

Those involved in outdoor sports, especially, are particularly vulnerable. Sports such as cricket, football, athletics, and field hockey require extended hours of training under the sun, leading to significant loss of electrolytes and minerals through sweat. Now you may ask, why do we even need these electrolytes?

Our human body relies on a delicate balance of electrolytes and minerals to function optimally. Electrolytes like sodium, potassium, magnesium, and calcium play crucial roles in maintaining fluid balance, muscle function, and overall cellular health. During intense physical

activity, especially in high temperatures, the body sweats to cool down. Sweat contains not only water but also these essential electrolytes.

Electrolytes do more than just regulate fluids. They have many important functions, including:

- Transmitting nerve signals from the heart, muscles, and nerve cells to other cells
- Building new tissue
- Supporting blood clotting
- Keeping your heart beating by electrically stimulating muscle contractions
- Maintaining the blood's pH level
- Regulating the fluid level in blood plasma

When the body loses a significant amount of electrolytes through sweat, it can lead to dehydration, muscle cramps, fatigue, and decreased performance. Sodium is the primary electrolyte lost in sweat, followed by potassium and magnesium. These electrolytes are vital for nerve function, muscle contraction, and maintaining blood pressure. Without adequate replenishment, you can experience severe decline in performance and even heat-related illnesses.

I've got these simple and effective additions to help you prevent

electrolyte loss and ensure optimal performance during the summer months without making any changes to your diet.

Stay hydrated with cooling beverages

- Coconut water: Rich in potassium and other electrolytes, coconut water is a natural hydrator. It's an excellent alternative to sugary sports drinks. An average green coconut provides about 1/2–1 glass of coconut water. One glass (240 ml) contains only 60 calories. In fact, a 2014 study out of Brazil found that coconut water improved exercise capacity better than water or a sports drink during a very hot day.

- Buttermilk and curd: Traditional Indian drinks like buttermilk (*chaas*) and curd (*dahi*) are not only cooling but also packed with calcium and probiotics, which aid digestion and hydration.

- Infused water: Adding slices of fruits like lemon, cucumber, and mint to water can make it more refreshing and palatable, encouraging more frequent hydration.

Incorporate fruits into your diet

- Watermelon and melons: These fruits have high water content and are rich in vitamins and minerals, making them perfect for staying hydrated and replenishing lost